
A Closer Look at Brown's Academic Experience

1 message

Brown University <admission@messages.brown.edu>
Reply-To: Brown University <admission@brown.edu>
To: hakamaneshkarimi@gmail.com

Wed, Sep 23, 2026 at 9:18 PM



BROWN

Office of College Admission



Dear Colleague,

One of the questions we hear most often is, "*What does the Open Curriculum actually look like in practice?*" While Brown's academic model is distinctive, it is grounded in a simple philosophy: students thrive when they have the opportunity to pursue their academic interests with both freedom and intention.

As you advise students considering Brown, here are a few key aspects of the undergraduate academic experience:

- The Open Curriculum encourages exploration while maintaining academic rigor. Students are free to design their own path to a degree that reflects their interests without a set of general education requirements.
- Students pursue concentrations. Similar to majors at many institutions, concentrations provide depth in a chosen field while allowing students to explore across disciplines. Many students even choose to double concentrate, pursuing

fields that are closely connected or entirely different, creating an academic path that's uniquely their own. Students can also choose from several certificate programs, comparable to minors at other colleges, as a complement to a similar concentration or something completely different.

- Shopping Period supports informed choices. At the start of each semester, students can attend (“shop”) courses before deciding which to add to their schedules.
- Brown's grading philosophy promotes intellectual curiosity. Students are encouraged to challenge themselves, explore new subjects, and pursue areas of interest in an environment that values learning and growth while giving them the flexibility to take academic risks. The Satisfactory/No Credit (S/NC) option reinforces this by enabling students to explore new areas of study and take intellectual risks without impacting their GPA.
- Advising begins early. Students work closely with faculty, staff, and peer advisors throughout their academic journey as they explore interests, select courses, and plan for future opportunities. Through the Meiklejohn Peer Advising Program, first-year students benefit from the perspective of trained student advisors who help them navigate academics, campus resources, and the transition to Brown.

Brown's academic experience is designed to give students the flexibility to ask new questions, pursue evolving interests, and chart their own educational path. For many students, that freedom is one of the defining aspects of a Brown education.

We invite you to explore our academic resources to learn more about the Open Curriculum and how Brown supports students in making the most of it

[Learn more about the Open Curriculum](#)

Sincerely,

Office of College Admission
Brown University

Take a Virtual
Tour

[Get Started](#)

Watch our Info
Session

[Watch](#)

College Cost
Estimator

[Estimate](#)